OSHA Guidelines for the Safe Operation of Powered Industrial Trucks (PITs)

Operating Rules & Safety Standards Notice

Issued in accordance with 29 CFR Part 1910.178

NOTICE

This reference guide outlines the essential safety standards for Powered Industrial Truck (PIT) operators.

Certified operators are expected to perform their duties in accordance with these standards, which serve as a baseline for safe and compliant operation. Adhering to OSHA requirements involves not only understanding these guidelines but also actively enforcing them through effective training programs.

The following safe operating rules reflect all applicable OSHA regulations.

Each certified forklift operator will receive a copy of these **Operating Rules** and will be required to acknowledge their receipt and understanding by signing a confirmation form.

Additionally, it is strongly recommended that a copy of these rules be posted on a bulletin board in areas where forklift operations take place. This will help meet OSHA and Cal/OSHA compliance requirements.

Rules of Operation

1.- Authorized Operators Only

Only trained and authorized employees may operate industrial trucks, pallet jacks, or tow tractors. Employers must provide proper training in the safe operation of all powered industrial trucks.

2.- Pre-Shift Inspections

Operators must inspect vehicles at the start of each shift. Any safety concerns must be reported immediately to a supervisor. Vehicles should not be operated until they are deemed safe. Inspections must include:

- Tires
- Horn
- Lights
- Battery
- Brakes
- Steering
- Lift components
- Electric pallet jacks must include checks on emergency stop systems

3.- Speed and Traffic Control

Vehicles must not exceed safe speeds. Maintain a safe distance from other vehicles, follow all facility traffic rules, and always remain in full control.

4.- Safe Following Distance

Maintain at least three vehicle lengths or a 3-second gap between vehicles. Turns must be made at a safe speed to prevent tipping, especially due to the high center of gravity of forklifts and pallet jacks.

5.- No Passengers

No one may ride on forks or unauthorized areas. If lifting a person is required, a secured safety platform must be used with the following:

- 42" guardrails
- Mid-rail
- 4" toe boards
- Securement to mast
- 7' overhead guard for protection

6.- No Horseplay

Stunt driving and horseplay are strictly prohibited.

Rules of Operation (continued)

7.- Secure Loads

Never move a vehicle with an unstable or unsecured load.

8.- Leaving a Vehicle Unattended

A vehicle is considered unattended if the operator is 25 feet away and out of view.

When leaving a vehicle:

- Shut off power
- Set brakes
- Lower forks
- Return mast to vertical
- Block wheels if on an incline

9.- Temporarily Dismounted Operators

If within 25 feet and in view of the vehicle:

- Lower forks
- Neutralize controls
- Set brakes

10.- Protect Pedestrians

Never drive toward a person near a fixed object. Always ensure people are clear before moving.

11.- Look Before You Move

Always look in the direction of travel. Pedestrians have the right of way.

12.- Elevator Use

Do not enter elevators without authorization. Ensure load and elevator capacity compliance. Power must be off and brakes set once inside.

13.- Entering Confined Areas

Enter elevators or tight spaces with the load end forward.

14.- Dock Safety

Do not operate on or in trucks/trailers until they are chocked and brakes are set.

15.- Floor Load Limits

Operate only on surfaces that can support the full weight of the loaded vehicle.

Rules of Operation (continued)

16.- No Riding on Forks or Sides

Employees must not ride on forks, backs, or sides of trucks or jacks.

17.- Proper Riding Facilities Only

No riders unless the vehicle is equipped with proper seating and safety restraints.

18.- Fork Height

Carry forks as low as possible—typically 4 to 6 inches from the ground.

19.- Tilt with Caution

Exercise care when tilting loads. Tilting can shift the center of gravity and cause tipping.

20.- Repeat of Dock Safety

Do not enter trucks/trailers unless securely blocked and brakes are set. Always chock wheels.

21.- Operating on Grades

- Ascend/descend slowly
- On steep grades (>10%), travel with load upgrade
- Tilt load back slightly
- Hand/powered pallet jacks: operate downgrade

22.- Avoid Crush Hazards

Keep all body parts inside the operator's area. Avoid areas between mast uprights or pinch points.

23.- No Standing Under Elevated Loads

Never allow anyone beneath raised forks or loads unless securely blocked.

24.- Railroad Tracks

Cross diagonally. Do not park within 9 feet of track centerlines.

25.- Edge Clearance

Maintain at least one tire-width distance from edges on docks or platforms.

Rules of Operation (continued)

26.- Check Flooring

Inspect flooring of trucks, trailers, or railcars before driving onto them.

27.- Passing Restrictions

Do not pass at intersections, blind spots, or other hazardous areas.

28.- Sound Horn at Crossings

Slow down and use the horn where visibility is limited. If the load blocks the view, drive in reverse.

29.- Operating on Grades

- Ascend/descend slowly
- On steep grades (>10%), travel with load upgrade
- Tilt load back slightly
- Hand/powered pallet jacks: operate downgrade

30.- Do Not Overload

Never exceed rated capacity. Display weight limits clearly on the vehicle, ideally on the mast and operator view.

31.- Jack Use

Enter elevators with the load forward. Do not ride on pallet jacks or use them as scooters.

32.- Fluid Leaks

Do not operate any vehicle with fuel, oil, or hydraulic leaks.

33.- Improper Tilting

Do not tilt loads forward unless depositing. Excessive forward tilt can tip the vehicle.

34.- Securing Loads

Ensure loads are stable and securely supported before moving.

35.- Attachments

Use caution with attachments—they change the truck's center of gravity and rated capacity.

36.- Elevated Personnel

If lifting a person in a platform:

- The engine must remain running
- The operator must stay at the controls

37.- No Smoking or Open Flames

No smoking while operating forklifts or within 50 feet of battery charging or refueling areas. Chargers must be off before connecting/disconnecting.

DON'T FORGET TO

